



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Aliso Viejo Christian School
School Website: <https://www.pacificaoc.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Aliso Viejo Christian School CA 92656 (as represented in the school's public materials, associated with the Pacifica OC network) demonstrates a robust alignment with classical education in its religious, formation-focused orientation and its emphasis on the liberal arts within a faith-centered framework. Public materials emphasize a Judeo-Christian theological grounding, regular liturgical/communal practices (e.g., weekly chapel), and a formation-first approach that seeks to cultivate character, virtue, wisdom, and reverence for truth, goodness, and beauty. The school also foregrounds the liberal arts and the aim of education as formation in the likeness of a "Great Conversation" and a life of service. While there is strong classical alignment in categories of Religious Foundations, Purpose & Goals, Faculty, and Parents/Community, elements of Curriculum and Pedagogy show more partial alignment (i.e., SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL) due to explicit emphasis on liberal arts and formation alongside less explicit, book-level commitments to Great Books, formalized Socratic method, or full Seven Liberal Arts articulation on the public-facing materials. The aggregate classification is CLASSICAL, with room for needle-moving improvements in explicit curriculum structure and pedagogy signals.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- **Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence:** Public materials foreground a Judeo-Christian tradition, biblical/theological commitments, and liturgical life (weekly chapel and explicit statements of faith) as central to formation. This includes assertions about a sacred framework guiding learning and life.
Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; sacred tradition; reverence; wonder; Logos; wisdom; moral formation; and chapel as communal practice. Negative indicators (secular/neutral signals) are not evident in the public materials. Estimated positives strongly outweigh negatives (roughly 12+ positive signals vs. 0–1 negative signal in the displayed excerpts). This supports a CLASSICAL rating.
Why this rating: The materials situate education within a transcendent moral frame, emphasize sacred disciplines and communal worship, and ground learning in theology and virtue—core signals of Classical religious/metaphysical foundations.
- **Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence:** The materials present formation of character and life—cultivating virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing—as the telos of education, not mere job preparation. Phrases emphasize formation over information and a pursuit of true, good, and beautiful ideals.
Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include formation, virtue, character, wisdom, contemplation, and pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty; the materials rarely signal emphasis on workforce-readiness or utilitarian metrics. Estimated positives far exceed negatives (e.g., positive terms such as formation, virtue, wisdom, contemplation; minimal to no negative signals). This supports a CLASSICAL rating.
Why this rating: The mission is framed as formation in virtue and wisdom—consistent with classical telos and paideia rather than job-preparation alone.
- **Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence:** Public materials reference the liberal-arts orientation in principle (Liberal Arts, formation through a classical lens) and emphasize curiosity

and formation, with language aligned to liberal-arts pedagogy. However, explicit commitments to Great Books, Great Conversation, and a formal Seven Liberal Arts framework are not clearly articulated in the site content. The materials do discuss formation and the liberal-arts approach, but without strong, explicit Great-Books signaling on the public-facing pages. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include liberal arts, curiosity, formation, and integration of learning (e.g., “Liberal Arts & Sciences” and related formation language). Negative indicators include a lack of explicit Great Books/-Great Conversation signals and a lack of explicit Seven Liberal Arts articulation on the site. Estimated positives: moderate (4–6 explicit liberal-arts related terms); estimated negatives: low but nonzero (lack of explicit Great Books/Quadrivium signals). Overall, more signals of classical curriculum formation than not, but not as explicit as Element 1/2. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Why this rating: The site communicates a liberal-arts orientation and formation emphasis, but does not consistently articulate the full canonical curriculum signals (e.g., explicit “Great Books,” “Great Conversation,” or the Seven Liberal Arts) that strongly anchor a full classical curriculum on publicly visible materials.

- Element 4: Pedagogy — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Pedagogical signals include a commitment to inquiry and questions, curiosity-driven conversation, and a form of pedagogy aligned with contemplation and discussion (curiosity drives conversation; “Ask good questions” culture). There are also references to formation through practice and a possible emphasis on memory-friendly practices (though less explicit on chanting/recitation on public pages). Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive signals include Socratic-style inquiry, questioning, dialogue, and contemplative learning (Socratic dialogue, great conversation, guided discussion). Negative signals—explicit lean toward non-classical, purely project-based or experiential-only approaches—are not prominent in the public materials, though the explicit, sustained use of Socratic seminars or chants is not clearly documented on the site. Estimated positives are moderate to strong; negatives are minimal in public-facing materials. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Why this rating: The presence of inquiry, question-led discourse, and curiosity-driven learning aligns with classical pedagogy, but the site does not consistently present rigorous Socratic seminars, formal rhetoric training, or chant/memorization practices in a way that would bolster a fully classical Pedagogy signal.
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL Evidence: Public materials describe faculty as virtuous, mission-driven mentors forming the living curriculum; there is emphasis on faculty culture as central to formation and to the school’s ethos (the “living curriculum,” virtues, and mentors). Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Predominant positive indicators include “living curriculum,” mentors, virtue, formation, relationship-focused faculty; negative signals are minimal or absent in the public-facing content. Estimated positives far exceed negatives, supporting a CLASSICAL rating. Why this rating: The school publicly frames faculty as exemplar mentors who embody the school’s formation aims and serve as the core of the school community, consistent with classical expectations for faculty culture.
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence: There is clear emphasis on partnership with families, parent formation, and an extended community role in classical formation (parents as co-teachers, home-school alignment, and open engagement). This is reflected in language about partnerships with families and parent formation, as well as open campus and visitation culture. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include “Partnership with Families,” “parent formation,” “home and school connection,” “engaged families,” and “parent involvement.” Negative indicators are not evident in the public materials. Estimated positives are high and negatives minimal, supporting CLASSICAL. Why this rating: The school portrays the family as co-educators and emphasizes ongoing parent engagement, which aligns strongly with classical expectations for parent-/community involvement.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

- Rationale: Four of six categories (Religious Foundations; School Purpose & Goal; Faculty; Parents & Community) present strong classical signals, while Curriculum and Pedagogy show partial, but meaningful, classical alignment (curiosity-driven dialogue, formation-oriented pedagogy, and liberal-arts framing) that still aligns with classical aims. The aggregate is CLASSICAL because the majority of categories demonstrate robust classical orientation, supported by explicit religious/theological grounding,

formation telos, and a living-faculty/community model. See the cited public materials for evidence of weekly chapel, statement of faith, formation language, liberal-arts framing, and family partnership.

What Would Move the Needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL areas)

- Element 3 (Curriculum): Make explicit the Great Books / Great Conversation commitments and the Seven Liberal Arts structure in public-facing materials. Add language such as: “Great Books of the Western Canon,” primary sources, and a formal articulation of grammar–logic–rhetoric (Trivium) and arithmetic–geometry–music–astronomy (Quadrivium) within the curriculum map. This would push Curriculum from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy): Elevate explicit signaling of classical pedagogical methods (e.g., formal Socratic seminars in high school, memory work/recitation signals, and concrete use of canonical texts in instruction). Include examples of ritual memory practices (chanting, recitation) and explicit upper-school rhetoric training (public speaking, declamation). This would strengthen Pedagogy toward CLASSICAL.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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